

Editorial: Follow the lead of Chief Braun

NOV 10, 2026 | 11:33 AM

There’s no better illustration of dysfunctional Toledo city government than the dueling views on the Toledo Police Department’s Flock cameras held by council and the police department.

Six councilmen, despite a city charter that wisely prohibits them from operational authority over city safety forces, have been pushing a resolution for weeks, urging the Kapszukiewicz administration to terminate the TPD contract with Flock.

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New TPD Chief Kevin Braun, one week into his new job, told Blade reporter Kelly Kaczala the need to embrace new technology is a primary focus for his leadership because there are going to be fewer officers.

Chief Braun says that’s a universal police department problem. In Toledo, thanks to the failure of the four-year, 0.25-percent income tax increase for neighborhood

safety, the city is looking at significant layoffs and will not be able to fund a new police class.

There's no doubt that irresponsible rhetoric from Toledo City Council on "mass surveillance" created a climate of distrust that contributed to the levy's failure with voters.

With big police and fire layoffs inevitable and understaffing likely for years because of both the elimination of a class of new recruits and a $50 million structural deficit in the city budget, the absolute last thing TPD should do is eliminate Flock cameras.

"It is by far the most useful tool we have ever had in this department. Flock works. We enjoy, on average, a homicide clearance rate between 80 [percent] to 90 percent every year. It is a tool our detectives use in just about every single case they investigate," Chief Braun said. "It would be so detrimental to lose that. It would set us back in a big way."

As we mull over Toledo City Council's attempts to "set back" the police department, let's remember these meddlers have no authority for management of TPD and have been told repeatedly by former Chief Michael Troendle and current Chief Braun of Flock's effectiveness as a crime fighting tool.

Council has the final say on the city budget. And because it's so tight, that's where their attention should be focused.

New TPD Chief Braun has shown deep understanding of the structural financial challenges police can only overcome through the savvy use of technology.

Council should listen, learn, and let Chief Braun lead without getting in the way of effective law enforcement by overstepping the authority granted them by the citizens of Toledo.

First Published November 10, 2026, 11:33 a.m.